

June 2026

Australian Government response to the Senate Committee report on the Agriculture (Biosecurity Protection) Levies Bill 2024 and related bills

About this response

The Senate referred the Agriculture (Biosecurity Protection) Levies Bill 2024 and related bills (the bills) to the Rural and Regional Affairs and Transport Legislation Committee (the Committee) for inquiry and report on 21 March 2024.

The Committee tabled its report on 10 May 2024. The report made one recommendation that the bills be passed. The Coalition Senators' dissenting report made two recommendations; (1) that the Australian Government properly consult on a sustainable biosecurity funding mechanism, and (2) that the Senate does not pass the bills.

The Senate resolved to discharge the bills from the Notice Paper on 12 February 2025.

The Australian Government's response to the Committee's report was tabled in the Senate on 18 June 2026.

Introduction

The Australian Government welcomes the opportunity to respond to the Senate Rural and Regional Affairs and Transport Legislation Committee (Committee) report: Agriculture (Biosecurity Protection) Levies Bill 2024 [Provisions] and related bills, tabled on 10 May 2024.

The Committee made one recommendation. The Coalition Senators' dissenting report made two recommendations.

The bills that would provide for the imposition, collection and administration of the Biosecurity Protection Levy (the BPL bills) passed the House of Representatives on 27 March 2024. On 12 February 2025, the Senate resolved to discharge the bills from the Notice Paper.

The Australian Government's response to the report is below. The response addresses recommendation 1 in the dissenting report. The Department of the Prime Minister and Cabinet's Tabling Guidelines of July 2024 do not require a government response to recommendations that a bill be passed (report recommendation 1) or not passed (dissenting report recommendation 2).

Coalition dissenting report

Recommendation 1

That the Australian Government properly consult on a sustainable biosecurity funding mechanism including:

- a full cost recovery basis for managing biosecurity risks of both passengers and commodities entering Australia; and
- an import container levy to pay for the biosecurity risk created.

Government response

The Australian Government notes this recommendation.

The Australian Government has invested over \$1 billion to support the Commonwealth's biosecurity activities. The Australian Government remains committed to a sustainably funded biosecurity system. The Senate has withdrawn the BPL bills from the Notice Paper and the Australian Government acknowledges that these bills will not be part of the ongoing funding solution.

The Australian Government's 2023-24 Budget 'Strengthened and sustainably funded biosecurity system package' provided:

- an ongoing uplift in taxpayers' contribution to biosecurity activities;
- a \$10 increase to the Passenger Movement Charge from \$60 to \$70 per traveller that commenced on 1 July 2024;
- a return to full cost recovery for importers from 1 July 2023, including annual reviews to ensure that cost recovery keeps pace with the cost of delivering biosecurity services; and
- the introduction of a new cost recovery charge for biosecurity clearance of declared low value goods brought into Australian territory, that commenced on 1 October 2024.

A Biosecurity Funding and Expenditure report is now published annually, in consultation with the Advisory Panel. This report delivers on the Australian Government's commitment to provide greater transparency of biosecurity activities, budget and expenditure.

The Australian Government has, and will continue to, consult biosecurity stakeholders, including through the Sustainable Biosecurity Funding Advisory Panel, to ensure a sustainably funded biosecurity system into the future.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/reporting/obligations/government-responses/biosecurity-protection-levies-bill>